Jezelle the Gazelle

By Dominique Morisseau

JEZELLE - Black girl, 12-13 years old. Spunky. Sassy. Full of energy and wit.

JEZELLE: We was runnin' like the wind. Me, Rasheed, and Spider. Reason why we call him that don't match. We was gonna call him Skinny but it's already another Skinny J on the block and you can't do repeats. Rasheed say it's bad luck to kill a Spider so it's actually increasing his life expectancy for us to call him that so he liked it and it's cool.

We be racin'. Everyday on the block. Spider be third place always, but me and Rasheed be neck and neck. Last race was a tie if you ask me, but Rasheed swear he beat me. That's complete bull but wasn't no witnesses. *"Get some witnesses!"* I told him. So he did. Rematch. I'll be the only girl. It's cool, I'm used to it. I'm always the only girl.

Five dollar admission for the big race. That was Spider's idea. I tried to tell him you can't charge people for getting onto their own block. That's like what they did to the Indians and the Africans and whatever. But he say people willin' to pay. And if they willin', then it's stupid not to take it. *If people wanna give you they money, it's like immoral or anti-American not to take it or whatever.*

INTRODUCTION

In this selection three 12-year-olds make plans for an old-fashioned foot race – a race with all their parents and friends watching. You can't get more childhood nostalgia and "American pie" than that . . . right? But ***race*** *matters and so does perception and implicit bias.*

Brian L. Wright explains: Throughout the United States, Black boys tend to be viewed as troublemakers from a very young age. Adults often see Black boys as older and less innocent than their White peers (a practice called adultification), and their play is perceived as more dangerous and violent."*

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JEZELLE: The whole block start buzzin'. Race this Friday. Best runners in the 'hood. Come put yo' money down. Winner gets half of the pot. That was Spider's idea too. He say he get to keep the other half cuz chargin' people was his idea.

I'm gettin' that short sprint perfected cuz one day I'ma do Olympics. Gold medal baby. That's the long term. Short term I just wanna beat Rasheed. This was him against her. Pre-teen man against pre-teen woman. This is for Equal rights and Democracy. All women and men created equal. I'm like a Civil Rights runner. Game on.

No adults invited to the race, but we all got feelin's that they'll be watchin' from the windows. My mama offers to make me a "Jezelle the Gazelle" t-shirt. I tell her I don't do rhymes. That's corny. But she makes me one anyway. I got a feelin' she's not takin' this race seriously. This is life or death. This is for Democracy and Equal rights for the only girls on every block. This is for neighborhood pride and respect. This is for real. This is not a game. But Mama makes the shirt magenta. I love magenta. I wear it but I'm not smiling for pictures. A woman's gotta have her boundaries.

Race day comes. We in school just waitin' for the bell to ring cuz now other folks in class done heard and the $5 pot is up to like $100. I've been eyein' this new 10 speed at Greg's Bike Shop. It's magenta with yellow stripes. It's got Jezelle's name all over it. I'ma be rollin' that baby up the block right past Rasheed, like "Whassup yo! Need a lift???" I got this race.

Spider wasn't feelin' good this day. He kept walkin' slow and dragging his feet. He looked like something was type heavy on his mind. I asked him what was up. *(BEAT)*

SPIDER: *We gotta move. To Cali. My aunt's house. My brother's in trouble. Some cops came by the house last night lookin' for him. He got these friends and . . . maybe they did somethin'. My mama said they the wrong influence. She can't take it no more. Said we gotta get out before they take us all under.*

JEZELLE: It sounded like he was saying goodbye forever. I didn't know what to do. I just looked at him for a second. A really long second. Then I just kiss him. Right out the blue. Ain't even

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sure what came over me. I'm not the kissin' type. I was totally another Jezelle. I started to feel my eyes itch like they wanted to cry. But I didn't. Cuz I never cry. Not even when my heart is breakin'. I had a race to win.

Ready. Set. We was on the startin' line at the front of the block. Rasheed had gotten his hair cut. He looked fresh and clean. But so what. I had my magenta baby doll runner Jezelle the Gazelle t-shirt. My mama was lookin' through the window and wavin' --- CORNY. Another mama, one uncle, Skinny J's father, and Ms. Jefferson--they was all lookin' out their windows. Everybody was there. And almost 20 kids from school. This had turned into the biggest race of my life. I stretched my calves. Rotated my ankles. Grabbed my elbow behind my back. No mistakes.

Spider was gonna run too. Just for kicks. Everybody knew he was no match for me and Sheed. But he was just runnin' behind us, for ol' times sake. Burnt Skin Ernie was holdin' the banner at the other end of the block. I was keepin' my eyes on the prize. Skinny J called it: *On your march.* We corrected him. *On your* ***marks.*** *Get set.* I was sweatin' now. *GO!!!!!!*

We was runnin' like the wind! I could feel myself like elevatin' almost. My lungs was on fire. All sound disappeared. All I could hear was my own heartrate. My own feet bouncin' against the street. Didn't see Rasheed in sight. It was me! I was in the lead! I pulled in closer. Closer! BANG! My body tore through the sheet that said WINNER. I looked back to see the crowd cheering. I could hear their voices like sirens. *(PAUSE)*

But that wasn't cheers. That was screaming. And it wasn't a sound effect. It was real sirens. And Rasheed wasn't on my heels. He was behind me. Far far behind me. On the ground. Not moving. Not moving. Not moving. And Spider. . . Spider. . . wasn't in third place. He wasn't running either. He was on the ground. Not moving. Not moving. Not moving.

And the screams were sirens. And the sirens were screams. And there was a police on foot. And he had a gun. And I couldn't breathe. I couldn't even breathe. And I just sat on the ground. Not a winner. Not anything anymore. Just a runner gasping for air. . . gasping gasping for air. *(LONG BEAT)*

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My mama cried and I didn't. She kept shaking her fists in the air. . . All I could make out was fragments. It sounded like she forgot how to speak in real sentences. *"Those boys didn't do"* and *'Just running a race."* and *'Ain't all running from crime"* and *"Didn't nobody hear"* and *"Had the wrong boys!"* and *"Weren't even the same age!"* I stopped listening and closed my ears. But sirens kept going. All night. All through my dreams. And I couldn't stop running. *(BEAT)*

Two weeks after the big race, I went back to school. It was strange without 'Sheed and Spider. Everybody kept askin' me if I was ok. All the teachers kept askin' me if I needed to talk. I didn't say nothin'. I don't know if I'll ever say nothin' again.

My mama came to pick me up. She didn't want me walkin' by myself. Not while things are still so fragile, she said. Not while people are out there upset and confused. They killed Spider and Sheed. They were chasin' those boys that hang with Spider's brother. They said they went running around our block. They said they had just robbed a store. Nobody has seen those boys. They must be hiding good. But Rasheed and Spider. . . everybody saw. And the officers said they yelled *STOP.* Said they yelled it three times. But nobody heard nothin'. We were runnin' a race. Nobody heard nothin'. But everybody saw. *(BEAT)*

I still go to the track. One day I'ma do Olympics. Gold metal. One day I'ma be able to run without bein' afraid. But somedays still, when my feet are movin' fast and I can hear the wind in my ears, I look back to see who's runnin' after me. I look back to see who's left behind. I look back to wipe a tear from my eyes. . . even though I never cry. . . and then I look ahead and keep runnin'. For Rasheed. For Spider. For Equal rights. For Democracy. For the only girl on every block. For Civil Rights. And for everybody still in the race.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier
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Source for Brian L Wright quote in the introduction
https://www.edweek.org/leadership/opinion-stop-demonizing-black-boys-let-them-play-too/2022/11

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